

SEASON OF

SOPS

With speculation of early polls, the UPA Government goes into overdrive with its please-all policy, loosening its purse strings to dole out freebies that will leave the exchequer poorer

■ By Ashok K. Damodaran

Conventional wisdom suggests that in the last year of a government, people's expectations would be the lowest. Sometimes, the opposite can also be true, with a government that is nearing the end of its tenure suddenly turning very generous, loosening its purse strings and doling out sops, freebies and liberal promises of a better tomorrow.

In the normal course, the UPA Government would not have had to fight the next Parliamentary elections until at least another 18 months, but ever since Prime Minister Manmohan Singh used the pages of a Kolkata newspaper in mid-August to tell the Left parties, "You do whatever you want to do. You want to withdraw support (to the Government over the nuclear deal), so be it," the die seems to have been cast. UPA and its Left allies continue to indulge in shadow boxing over the nuclear agreement. Both sides give the impression of being intransigent but they also hope to keep the polls at bay for at least a few months. While the uncertainty over the Government's longevity persists, there is no doubt that the next elections would be held sooner than later. The political wrangling that followed Manmohan's "take it or leave it" diktat to the Left has sent virtually all parties and even state governments staging a pre-poll sop drive in a desperate bid to convince people that there is none better qualified to look after their interests. The prime minister himself set the ball rolling at the Red Fort in the Capital on August 15, when he listed the "achievements" of

his Government and went on to make lofty promises.

Consider some of the schemes announced or launched in the eight weeks since Manmohan dared the Left to withdraw support, fuelling speculation about snap polls. An old age pension scheme for senior citizens—over 65 years of age and living below the poverty line—will soon be launched. A new-age health insurance scheme for the poor is also in the pipeline. The prime minister has promised 6,000 new government-funded schools, colleges in 370 districts, 30 Central universities, 1,600 industrial training institutes and polytechnics, 10,000 vocational schools and 50,000 skill development centres, helping an estimated one crore students. No talk, of course, about where the money will come from or a time frame within which these ambitious projects are to be delivered.

The crisis in the agriculture sector has been deepening over the past three years, but it was only on Independence

